

Writing Strategies and Ethical Considerations

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Before designing a proposal, plan the overall structure or outline of the topics and their order

The structure of a proposal varies depending on the project design

- The proposal should follow good writing practices to ensure a **coherent research proposal or project that is easy to read.**
- In addition, special attention should be paid to **good ethical practices**, and **anticipating potential problems**



Writing Strategies and Ethical Considerations



Joseph A. Maxwell
(2013)

Regardless of the type of proposal, its contents should provide a **coherent picture of the entire project**

1. What do readers need to know to better understand your topic?

2. What do readers already know about your topic?

3. What do you propose to study?

4. What is the context, and who are the people you will study?

5. What methods do you plan to use to collect data?

6. How will you analyze the data?

7. How will you validate your findings?

8. What ethical issues will your study raise?

9. What do preliminary results show about the feasibility and value of the proposed study?

Problem Framing and Objectives

- Relevance
- Research objectives
- Research question / hypothesis

Purpose

- Theoretical
- Practical

Research Methods and Data

- Data collection
- Methods and instruments

Anticipation of Problems and Ethical Issues

- Theoretical
- Practical



(General) Structure of a Quantitative study

The structure of a quantitative study follows the **model of an introduction and literature review, methods, results, and discussion.**

A Introduction and Literature Review

- Statement of the problem (the problem, theory, existing literature on the problem, gaps or deficiencies in the literature, and the relevance of the study for different audiences)
- Purpose of the study
- Research questions or hypotheses

B Methods

- Population, sample, participants, and participant recruitment
- Type of research design (e.g., experimental, survey)
- Procedures (procedures and variables, instruments and materials, ethical considerations)

C Data Analysis Procedures

D Appendices

- Instruments and materials
- Study timeline
- Budget



(General) Structure of a Qualitative study

In qualitative research, **there is no single dominant structure.**

However, guidance presented in several general frameworks can be helpful.

A Introduction

- Statement of the problem (including existing literature, gaps or deficiencies in the literature, and the relevance of the study for different audiences)
- Purpose of the study
- Research questions
- Philosophical assumptions and/or worldview

B Procedures

- Research design (e.g., descriptive, case study)
- Role of the researcher
- Data collection processes
- Data analysis processes
- Proposed narrative structure for reporting findings
- Validation strategies
- Ethical considerations

C Expected Results, Impacts, and Significance of the Study

D Appendices

- Interview questions and interview protocol
- Observation forms
- Study timeline
- Budget



(General) Structure of a Mixed Methods study

A Introduction and Literature Review

- Statement of the problem (deficiencies in previous research, the need for both quantitative and qualitative data, and the understanding gained by combining or integrating both datasets)
- Purpose or objective of the study(the overall intent to collect and combine quantitative and qualitative data)
- Research questions and hypotheses
- Quantitative research questions or hypotheses
- Qualitative research questions
- Mixed-methods integration questions
- Philosophical assumptions or worldview and theory
- Literature review(typically includes quantitative, qualitative, and mixed-methods studies and demonstrates the need for a mixed-methods study)

B Methods

- Definition of mixed-methods research and justification
- Mixed-methods design
- Design diagram and validity challenges in the design
- Quantitative data collection(ordered according to the design)
- Quantitative data analysis
- Qualitative data collection
- Qualitative data analysis
- Integration statement and joint display

C Resources and Skills Required to Conduct the Research

D Potential Ethical Issues

E Appendices

The Habit of Writing

It is useful to establish the discipline or habit of writing regularly and continuously. For this purpose, the use of **drafts** is very valuable.

- You gain perspective when you return to the study after a short break.
- An intermittent writing process often disrupts workflow (“weekend writer”).
- Continuous work on the study means writing something every day or, at the very least, being involved daily in the processes of : **thinking, gathering information, and reviewing**.



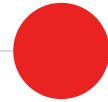
Set writing as a priority and make it a daily activity, regardless of mood or motivation.



Write when you feel most alert, during the day or at night.



Avoid writing marathons. Write in small, regular amounts.



Schedule writing tasks so you work in specific, manageable writing units during each session.

Clear and Concise Writing

The basic building blocks of any intellectual or research argument are **paragraphs**.

Each paragraph **should be a single unit of thought**, a package of ideas made up of closely related sentences.

1. Topic	Effective access to justice in Colombia faces multiple challenges.
2. Body	Despite advances in legislation and judicial reforms (DNP,2025), people continue to face significant barriers when dealing with justiciable problems, both from objective and subjective instances (OCDE, 2016). From an objective perspective, these barriers include a lack of relevant and accessible mechanisms for conflict resolution.
3. Evidence	For example, a recent study by the Center for Studies on Law, Justice, and Society (2016) suggested that 45% of Colombians living in rural areas must travel more than 20 kilometers to reach a judicial office. In addition, the World Bank (2019), in its annual report on access to justice, highlighted that only 30% of municipalities in Colombia have extrajudicial conciliation centers, which limits access to alternative dispute resolution mechanisms.
4. Closing	Overcoming these barriers through improvements in judicial infrastructure and the implementation of alternative dispute resolution mechanisms is essential to guaranteeing access to justice, thereby laying the foundations for a more equitable and effective system.

[How to write paragraphs in research texts \(articles, books and PhDs\) | Writing for Research](#)

Clear and Concise Writing

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1. Topic

The initial topic sentence alerts readers to a change in topic or focus and indicates, through signposting, what the paragraph is about.

- It should never be linked to the material that came before (all links are made forward, in the closing sentences).
- Be careful not to begin paragraphs with linking words such as “However,” “Nevertheless,” “Moreover.”

Topic sentences should clearly signal a new focus of attention.

- They should give readers a sense of a smooth and “natural” progression of thought.
 - A very brief indication or naming prompt, not a mini-guide or an advance summary of the entire paragraph’s argument.
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2. Body

The main body sentences present the central argument of the paragraph. In research writing, they should:

- Clearly explain reasoning
- Describe results
- Develop implications
- Clarify formulas
- Elaborate and explain theoretical and thematic points

Body sentences constitute the main flow of the paragraph, the core of the unit of thought.

Clear and Concise Writing

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3. Evidence

Evidence sentences may be distributed throughout a paragraph, interspersed among body sentences at points where they are most necessary or useful. Evidence includes:

- Examples
- References
- Citations from other authors
- Supporting facts
- Exhibits, tables, graphs, or diagrams.

Evidence sentences are inherently digressive: they have the potential to interrupt the main flow of the paragraph.

- Therefore, they require careful management, especially when two or more evidence sentences appear consecutively without intervening body sentences.
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Clear and Concise Writing

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4. Closing

The closing sentence serves to:

- Pull the paragraph's argument together
- Make clear to readers that a building block has been established.

It should be:

- Constructive and substantive
- Add value to the argument, rather than simply repeat earlier material.

The closing sentence should also manage any necessary transition to the next paragraph.

Clear and Concise Writing

Starting with a backward-looking link to the previous paragraph

Readers may conclude that this is simply “more of the same” and move on to the next paragraph. **Even those who persist may become confused:**

- What is the paragraph about?
- Is it the first sentence?
- Or is the real point the now “submerged” topic sentence that appears second?

Abrupt breaks caused by length

This commonly occurs when evidence sentences multiply: a brief, planned presentation of an example or the analysis of an exhibit becomes too long, breaking the paragraph’s flow.

Overly long paragraphs

Paragraphs extend beyond the acceptable range for research writing, which is typically: **100–200 words and may reach 300 words or more.**

Overly short paragraphs

In research writing, this occurs when a paragraph has: **fewer than 100 words, especially when it consists of a single sentence or fewer than 50 words.**



Beginning with a “clarifying” sentence or some other formal or insubstantial statement.

Examples include opening by discussing:

- a caveat
- a definition
- a difficulty
- a methodological issue that belongs to the background of the argument rather than its core.

As a result, readers may fail to correctly identify the topic sentence, and therefore the closing sentence becomes unjustified.

Starting with quotations and/or references

When the first words of a paragraph are the name of another author, the writer inadvertently signals: “*What follows is a completely derivative paragraph*”(or section, if the pattern is repeated). To avoid this:

- Write a clear and independent topic sentence.
- Explain the central ideas or propositions of one or more schools of thought in the body sentences.
- Relegate authors’ names to supporting references at the end of sentences.

Clear and Concise Writing

It is important to develop editorial skills

- Eliminate unnecessary words(while retaining essential ones)
- Eliminate the passive voice(by using the active voice)
- Reduce qualifiers and value judgments
- Reduce the excessive use of citations, italics, footnotes, and parenthetical comments.

Regarding Voice and Tense

- Use the **active voice** as much as possible in academic writing.
- There is a common practice of using the **past tense to review the literature and report** results of previous studies
- **Future tense** appropriately indicates that the study will be conducted in the future and is a key tense used in research proposals.
- Use the present tense to add clarity to a study, especially in the introduction.

Active Voice: The **researchers** **identified** significant **barriers to access to justice**. They implemented programs to build new conciliation centers.

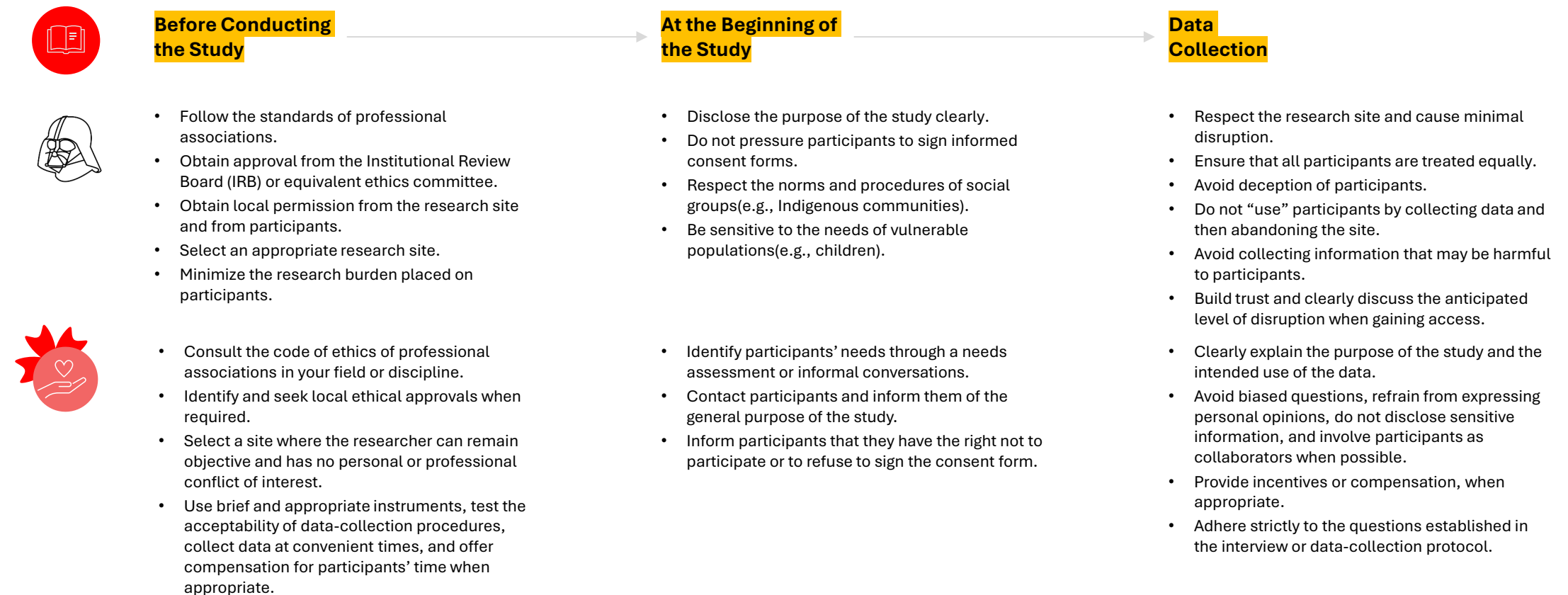
Subject + **verb** + **direct object**

Passive Voice: Significant **barriers to access to justice** **were identified** by the **researchers**. Programs were implemented to build new conciliation centers.

Subject + **passive verb phrase** + **agent complement**

Ethical Considerations

In addition to conceptualizing the process of writing a proposal or research study, it is necessary to anticipate ethical issues and design strategies to address them.



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Data Analysis



- Avoid taking sides with participants.
- Avoid disclosing only positive results.
- Respect participants' privacy and anonymity.



- Report multiple perspectives.
- Report contradictory findings.
- Assign fictitious names or aliases and develop composite participant profiles to protect identities.

Reporting, Sharing, and Storing Data

- Avoid falsification of authorship, evidence, data, findings, and conclusions.
- Do not plagiarize.
- Avoid disclosing information that could harm participants.
- Communicate in clear, direct, and appropriate language.
- Share data with others when appropriate.
- Store raw data and related materials(e.g., procedural details, instruments).
- Do not duplicate or fragment publications.
- Provide full evidence of ethical compliance and absence of conflicts of interest, if requested.
- Indicate who owns the data generated by the study.
- Report findings honestly. Use composite stories to protect participants' identities.
- Use bias-free language and avoid discriminatory language.
- Provide copies of reports to participants and stakeholders, and consider distribution via a website.
- Refrain from using the same material for more than one publication.
- Disclose research sponsors and those who benefit from the research.
- Give proper credit for intellectual ownership to researchers, participants, and advisors.

Ethical Considerations



Delaney
(2020)